

Young people do not lack critical thinking, thank you.

We lack confidence

Not everyone is lucky enough to attend a forum discussing [Sino-EU cooperation and AI governance](#), as I was last month. Yet, the young leaders panel did not include anyone under 30. So, when speakers described the origin of AI dependency of today's youth as a 'lack of critical thinking' and 'laziness', I felt compelled to share our side of the story.

The locus of the conversation is misplaced, concerns about critical thinking are not unique to AI. Similar debates were already taking place about the popularisation of newspapers, [then the television](#), the internet, and social media. While media literacy does not automatically translate into AI literacy, the underlying concern applies equally across technological revolutions. Governments and institutions, such as the OECD, are making efforts to [facilitate youth upskilling](#). However, they focus on education and learning rather than exploring the harmful outcomes of such dependencies.

In life, experience comes through trial and error. Growth comes from recognising one's weaknesses and improving by addressing them over time. When access to AI is given before the end of this formative period, people will opt for an AI-enabled "cognitive offload". It is an action meant to reduce the demand of a task through reliance on actions or objects. While a recent study showed it ultimately [reduces critical thinking skills](#), it is just one of the many symptoms.

Given that young people are seldom given platforms to express themselves, they cannot raise concerns about their experiences with AI. Initiatives for youth emphasise teaching how to prompt better or optimise interactions but do not provide support to explore how to prevent dependency in decision-making.

A phenomenon I have noticed among my peers (and, to some extent, myself) is how difficult it is to start a project from scratch and carry it through independently without external support. This is, in my opinion, the biggest challenge of young people's AI dependency.

Even when students have basic knowledge about a topic, they often feel compelled to consult an LLM before making meaningful progress. This habit has quickly been framed as laziness. I would say it is caused by [uncertainty, anxiousness, and the impostor syndrome](#). Moreover, a lack of understanding and support from older generations can reinforce this spiral.

Would you consider a child lazy when struggling to walk for the first time? Or would you offer them a helping hand (or perhaps something with wheels)? We support a child's first steps to build confidence to then walk unsupervised. Young people need to build confidence in their knowledge, their capabilities and resilience, before accessing AI. As it risks to become a balance bike next generations will never outgrow.

Throughout history, critical thinking has been a challenge. The fact that today's young people are struggling to think critically is not the fault of AI. Rather, early reliance on AI as a source of support for information gathering and project building risks weakening self-confidence further. Instead of starting new projects based on transferrable skills and knowledge, the background building would be dependent on tools or agents.

Young people consider AI extremely convenient. In the information age, digital natives are accustomed to accessing information fast. Everything must be immediate and high quality. So, when LLMs provide immediate answers to any question or problems, untrained people are less likely to undertake long-form research, or ponder costs and benefits to personal decisions on their own.

Moreover, studies show that poor [mental health is a strong predictor of AI dependency](#). Young people often overlook LLMs mistakes. They hallucinate, yes, but if you are already full of self-doubt, you regard your own mistakes as worse, and less forgivable. Youth, and in particular vulnerable groups, lack the resilience to spend emotional or cognitive effort addressing an issue or answering a question. They **fear their weaknesses and mistakes might reflect their worth**, rather than their potential for improvement.

Tackling new tasks or problems independently is a skill that needs to be taught before access to LLMs. Parents and educational institutions could receive guidance on how to facilitate this development. Following the example of a Dutch study on how [offline play improves digital literacy](#), we could introduce non-digital learning to build transferable skills. Schools, for example, could require students to undertake analogue personal projects each term.

This could encourage hobbies and interests outside education and build emotional resilience. Initiating offline activities can support the development of autonomy in a tangible setting where errors can be seen easier and physically corrected. The fear of making mistakes would be reduced through iterative improvement of [experiences in a real-life scenario](#). It is only with this newfound confidence that youth can exercise their critical thinking adequately.